

NC State - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | ACC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-45 baseline with a seven-win center and a relatively trustworthy quarterback/offensive structure, offset by major defensive turnover and a rebuilt pass-catcher room.
Preseason consensus	AP unranked, 0 votes · ACC media 7th · SP+ No. 43
Returning production	54% (No. 61) overall · Off. 62% (No. 37) · Def. 46% (No. 86)
Primer power rating	+5.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.1 wins · likely 7-5
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ Slightly worse overall, with offensive stability countered by a defensive rebuild
Confidence	Medium

2026 identity: OC Kurt Roper has stability in QB CJ Bailey and RB Jayden "Duke" Scott, but the pass-catching group is being rebuilt after major departures and WR Teddy Hoffmann's season-long suspension.

Bottom line: NC State is trustworthy at QB and staff, but eight-win upside depends on a rebuilt defense and pass-catching group holding up against a manageable No. 68 schedule.

Beats expectations if: QB CJ Bailey turns passing efficiency into a steadier offense, RB Jayden "Duke" Scott and RB Davion Gause stabilize the run game, and the new defense replaces NFL losses.

Disappoints if: The rebuilt WR/TE group misses its departed production and the low-continuity defense loses NG KaTron Evans or DB Jamel Johnson availability while again struggling to create havoc.

Five things to remember

- ? QB question:** QB CJ Bailey is the clear QB1 and a 2026 captain; unlike many teams in this tier, NC State does not enter the season with a quarterback competition.
- Defense:** The offense returns 62% of production (No.37), but the defense only 46% (No.86).
- Receiver room:** The pass-catcher room is rebuilt: WR Noah Rogers and WR Terrell Anderson transferred, TE Justin Joly and WR Wesley Grimes reached the NFL, and WR Teddy Hoffmann is suspended for 2026.
- ? Key uncertainty:** NG KaTron Evans is eligible for the Aug. 29 opener but not safely for the full season; DB Jamel Johnson's fifth-year availability is also unresolved after the Aug. 21 Tenth Circuit stay.
- Schedule pressure:** The schedule is only No.68 by SP+ and includes seven home games, giving a top-45 team a credible path back to the 7-9 win range if the rebuilt defense is functional.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	8-5 (5-4 ACC)	● Good
Scoring	30.2 PPG	● Good / above average
Total offense	391.2 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	145.5 YPG · 4.4 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	7.73 YPA · 26 TD / 10 INT	● Very good
Third downs	41.6%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	27.2 PPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Total defense	411.9 YPG allowed	● Poor
Rush defense	138.8 YPG · 4.3 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass defense	273.2 YPG · 7.56 YPA · 22 TD allowed	● Below average

NC State's offense was efficient enough to win, especially through the air, but not dominant by yardage or rushing. The defense was the bigger concern, with poor total and passing results despite a more respectable run front.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+2.92 · No. 44	● Good / above average
Off. EPA/play	+0.094 · No. 32	● Very good
Off. success rate	43.2% · No. 59	● Average / mixed
Off. explosive-play rate	13.2% · No. 43	● Good / above average
Havoc allowed	15.3% · No. 71	● Average / mixed
Opp.-adjusted defense	+0.05 · No. 67	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.014 · No. 70	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	39.7% · No. 45	● Good / above average
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	12.6% · No. 84	● Average / mixed
Havoc created	14.5% · No. 87	● Below average

Advanced-stat read: NC State's offense was better than its yardage rank because of efficient passing and positive EPA. The defense was more respectable down to down than total yardage suggests, but poor havoc and explosive prevention amplify the concern from low returning production.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Dave Doeren - returning same role	● ↔ Long-tenured program continuity keeps the overall structure stable.
OC/QB / offensive play caller	Kurt Roper - returning same role; offensive play-calling continuity	● ↔ Offensive system and play-calling continuity reduce transition risk around QB CJ Bailey.
DC/OLB	DJ Eliot - returning same core coordinator role	● ↔ Defensive-scheme continuity helps a low-returning-production unit, though game-day signal-calling specifics remain unresolved.
Co-DC / safeties-nickels	Charlton Warren - returning same role	● ↔ Secondary/coordinator continuity helps a rebuilt defensive backfield communicate through turnover.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ RB Davion Gause	North Carolina	● ↔ Projects as the primary complement to RB Jayden "Duke" Scott.
◆ WR Victor Snow	Buffalo	● ↔ Biletnikoff-watch transfer in the open receiver competition.
◆ WR Chance Robinson	Miami	● ↔ Major receiver-competition addition.
◆ WR Joshisa "Jojo" Trader	Miami	● ↔ Significant receiver-competition addition.
◆ TE Vander Ploog	Oregon	● ↔ Competes for a major role in the remade TE room.
◆ OL Jimarion McCrimon	East Carolina	● ↔ Projected left-tackle anchor after multiple OL departures.

Out	To	Loss
RB Hollywood Smothers	Texas	● ↓ Major 2025 running-back production transfers out.
WR Noah Rogers	Alabama	● ↓ Significant 2025 receiving production transfers out.
WR Terrell Anderson	USC	● ↓ Meaningful receiving production transfers out.
TE Justin Joly	NFL (Denver), Round 5, No. 152	● ↓ Forty-nine catches and seven TDs leave via the NFL draft.
WR Wesley Grimes	NFL (San Francisco 49ers), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 29 catches, 430 yards and three TDs leave for a confirmed NFL path.
OT Jacarrius Peak	South Carolina	● ↓ Experienced offensive-line starter transfers out.
OL Jalen Grant	No pro signing established	● ↓ Another experienced multi-year starter is absent from the 2026 roster after pro sweep.

Offensive net: Stable at QB, but WR, TE and parts of the OL are rebuilt; QB CJ Bailey must elevate the new supporting cast.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ ILB Popo Aguirre	Miami	● ↑ Current captain and defensive leader in the rebuilt front.
◆ EDGE Harvey Dyson III	Tulane	● ↔ Projected for a significant edge role.
◆ NG KaTron Evans	Marshall	● ↔ Expected for substantial nose-guard work, but only opener availability is currently secure.
◆ SAF King Mack	Penn State	● ↔ Prominent addition to a reworked secondary.

Out	To	Loss
LB Caden Fordham	NFL (Tampa Bay Buccaneers), undrafted free agent	● ↓ The 143-tackle team leader exits for the NFL.
DE Cian Slone	NFL (Las Vegas Raiders), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 61-tackle edge/front contributor exits to a confirmed NFL roster.

Out	To	Loss
DE Sebastian Harsh	NFL (Houston Texans), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 41-tackle 2025 edge contributor exits to a confirmed NFL roster.
DT Brandon Cleveland	NFL (Las Vegas), Round 7, No. 229	● ↓ 36-tackle interior defender becomes a drafted loss.
CB Devon Marshall	NFL (Jacksonville Jaguars), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 50 tackles and 18 passes defended leave for a confirmed NFL signing.
LB Sean Brown	NFL (Tennessee Titans), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 44 tackles in five games before injury leave for a confirmed NFL signing.
EDGE Kenny Soares Jr.	Michigan State	● ↓ Major 2025 defensive production transfers out.

Defensive net: The team’s biggest roster risk, with major veteran losses and only 46% returning production.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	OC Kurt Roper offense centered on QB CJ Bailey and RB Jayden "Duke" Scott.	Strong 2025 pass efficiency/EPA with WR Keenan Jackson as the clearest returning target.	Run-game inconsistency and heavy WR/TE turnover.
Defense	DC DJ Eliot/co-DC Charlton Warren continuity with a new core led by ILB Popo Aguirre.	Respectable 2025 success-rate and rush-defense foundation.	Poor havoc/explosive prevention and No. 86 defensive returning production.
Special teams	Field-goal continuity with unsettled punter/kickoff roles.	K Noah Vinesett returns.	SP+ No. 103 and an open punter role.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B+	● ↑	High	QB CJ Bailey is the established QB1 and team captain.
RB	● B	● ↔	High	RB Jayden "Duke" Scott is the clear RB1 after RB Hollywood Smothers departs.
WR	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	WR Keenan Jackson anchors a rebuilt room after major departures.
TE	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	TE Justin Joly’s NFL departure leaves TE Vander Ploog competing for a major role.
OL	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	OL Jimarion McCrimon projects at LT, but multiple veteran OL departures force a rebuild.
DL/Edge	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	NG KaTron Evans projects for major work, but full-season eligibility remains unresolved.
LB	● B–	● ↓	Medium	ILB Popo Aguirre captains a group replacing several veteran departures.
Secondary	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	CB Brian Nelson II provides captain continuity after CB Devon Marshall and other veterans depart.
Special teams	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	K Noah Vinesett returns, but punter remains open and SP+ ranks the unit No. 103.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	HC Dave Doeren, OC Kurt Roper, DC DJ Eliot and co-DC Charlton Warren provide strong continuity.
Overall	● B	● ↓	Medium	Top-45 baseline with stable QB/offensive structure, offset by major defensive turnover and a rebuilt pass-catcher room.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through August 24, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
CJ Bailey	QB	● Above-average Power 4 starter / team ceiling driver	Maxwell Award · Walter Camp Player of the Year	Established QB1 and captain gives NC State its clearest stability.
Jayden "Duke" Scott	RB	● Lead Power 4 back	Doak Walker Award · Paul Hornung Award	Captain and clear RB1 after RB Hollywood Smothers departs.
Keenan Jackson	WR	● Key returning receiver	-	Clearest returning pass-catcher in a rebuilt room.
◆ Victor Snow (TR: Buffalo)	WR	● High-upside transfer receiver / return candidate	Biletnikoff Award	Buffalo transfer is one of the most credentialed candidates to absorb vacated receiving work.
◆ Popo Aguirre (TR: Miami)	ILB	● Defensive leader / starting linebacker	-	Captain and centerpiece of the rebuilt front.
AJ Richardson	LB	● Proven returning defensive leader	-	Captain and one of the few high-confidence returning pieces in a low-continuity defense.
Brian Nelson II	CB	● Secondary leader / starting corner	-	Captain continuity after CB Devon Marshall and other veterans depart.
◆ KaTron Evans (TR: Marshall)	NG	● Projected major nose-guard role / eligibility monitor	-	Expected to play substantial opener snaps; full-season eligibility remains unresolved.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Manageable for a top-45 team: seven home games, two byes and only three top-30 SP+ opponents.
Difficulty	● 5/10 · SP+ SOS No. 68
Hardest stretch	at Vanderbilt → Appalachian State → Louisville → Wake Forest
Swing games	at Virginia, at Vanderbilt, Louisville, Wake Forest, Duke, at Florida State
Advantage	Seven home games and well-placed byes reduce sequencing stress before the late rivalry/road finish.
Expected	7.1 wins · likely 7-5
Floor / ceiling	5-7 / 9-3

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	NC State should be easier to price on offense than defense, and its favorable schedule can let the record outpace the underlying roster. Stable QB/play-caller structure supports seven-to-nine wins even if the rebuilt defense keeps the Wolfpack closer to upper-middle ACC quality.
Back them when	Opponents cannot pressure QB CJ Bailey or exploit the rebuilt defense vertically, especially in favorable home matchups.
Fade/pass when	Explosive offenses can stress the new defense, especially if NG KaTron Evans or DB Jamel Johnson availability is reduced.
Key monitor	NG KaTron Evans eligibility, DB Jamel Johnson status, WR/TE order, final OL combination, defensive havoc
Week 1 baseline	NC State +4.5 at Virginia · rating-only baseline; NC State primer +5.5 minus Virginia primer +8.0 minus 2.0 default road/home-field adjustment; no matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: NC State +5.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

NC State has a reliable offensive center in QB CJ Bailey and RB Jayden "Duke" Scott, but the pass-catching group and much of the defense are being rebuilt. The defensive returning-production rank of No. 86 is the largest structural concern.

A manageable schedule keeps seven to nine wins in play if the new defense is functional. The floor falls if eligibility issues thin the front or the rebuilt WR/TE group prevents QB CJ Bailey from carrying the offense.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching changes](#) · [QB preview](#) · [pass-catcher preview](#) · [defense preview](#) · [eligibility update](#) · [WR suspension](#) · [DB eligibility](#)

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